

ANIME

Log Horizon S3

★★★★☆ | While the premise of Log Horizon is very similar to that of most isekai, i.e., the protagonist gets stuck in another world, most cases a video game world, its execution is completely different. In Log Horizon's case, everyone's stuck in an online MMO called Elder Tale. At this point you could draw similarities to Sword Art Online, but don't. While the base premise is the same, Log Horizon deals with the more nitty gritty details of actually being stuck in a game world. Dealing with problems like food, player mentality and psyche, how lower level players are faring, what this means for the NPCs of the game world, how this transition has affected the politics of the game world and more.



All of these things are experienced primarily through the main protagonist of the show, Shiroe. Often referred to as the "Villain in glasses", he is anything but a villain, but is known to be shady

in order to get things done his way. He is a master strategist after all, being the primary decision maker for a group of "world first" raiders back when the game was still a game. His insight on things and the way he thinks make watching even what should be boring parts of the anime interesting.

The third season of Log Horizon continues where the second left off, with the arrival of "geniuses" who seem to be NPCs that like players can alter the game's world and seem to have it out for the players. Additionally, the players find that their own system of government, the round table, is crumbling, and they need a new method to keep things order, something that will accomodate not only players, but all the "people of the land" (NPCs) as well. If you're someone who has played online games in the past, and are interested in an anime with fantastic world-building, give Log Horizon a go.

COMIC

Falcon & Winter Soldier

★★★★☆ | Marvel is now confidently using the comics as an healthy exploration of what the audiences want, very pointedly modeled on accelerating the whole mango-anime-live action market in Japan. In the comics, the characters we are seeing in the new Disney live action series have already done their cool weird stuff that people are just finding out about, such as Wanda Maximoff building an entire constructed reality with a synthetic husband and children that makes her really wonky in the head. So the comic version of Bucky and Sam is a 5 issue series that concluded last year, and is a total yin yang thing that is all about exploring the stolen moments of serenity in the middle of a continuous call towards violence. It's funny, lighthearted, and freaking epic, because both the charac-



ters, Sam and Bucky, are so, so human in this strange world, human enough to save a kitty from the mafia, human enough to worry about why someone is not picking up the phone, and human enough to actively acknowledge that they need companionship and support in a very strange world. These are such refreshing superheroes really, not tied

up with their own agendas or abilities, they are really one of us, finding their way in the world, and figuring out how best to use their powers. The comics also launches frankly into a story about institutional problems, and perhaps the eager watchers of the TV series can get a lot of cues about the players being fielded by the US military, by reading the comics. Sam started off as a social worker in Harlem, a background that becomes very important. Here is the thing... that might get people excited. There is one player in all this, in the universe, that is intimately tied to what this story is about and where it is going... and that character is The Punisher. There is a lot of stuff going on here, and there is plenty to unpack for those who want to read between the lines. The panels are just full of action with the BIFF or BAM stuff things that comics are stereotypically famous for, so that is a lot of satisfaction right there, and the frozen action in these panels are laid out like the storyboard of an action movie, that you can imagine in your head as you read. This is just the right time to eat this short series whole.